Ad beatissimi Apostolorum Principis

Benedict XV · 1914-11-01 · English

TO OUR VENERABLE BRETHREN, THE PATRIARCHS, PRIMATES, ARCHBISHOPS, BISHOPS AND OTHER LOCAL ORDINARIES HAVING PEACE AND COMMUNION WITH THE APOSTOLIC SEE.

POPE BENEDICT XV VENERABLE BRETHREN, HEALTH AND THE APOSTOLIC BLESSING

When, by the unsearchable counsel of God's providence, and with- out any merit of Our own, We were called to the Chair of the most blessed Prince of the Apostles - for the same voice of Christ Our Lord which came to Peter came also to Us « feed my lambs, feed my 1 « sheep » - immediately We began to regard with unspeakable affection the flock committed to Our care: a flock truly immense, for in one way or another it embraces all mankind. For all, without exception, have been delivered by Jesus Christ, at the price of his blood, from the slavery of sin; nor is anyone shut out from the benefits of his Redem- ption. Therefore, as the divine Pastor has already happily gathered part of mankind into the fold of the Church, so, too, does he promise lovingly to constrain the rest: « And other sheep I have, that are' not 2 of this fold: them also I must bring, and they shall hear my voice ». We will not conceal from you, venerable Brethren, that Our heart's first movement, attributable only to God's goodness, was a wonderful impulse of zeal and of yearning for the salvation of all mankind; and in entering on the Pontificate, We made the selfsame supplication that Jesus made just before going to his death on the Cross: « Holy Fa- 3 ther, keep them in thy name whom thou hast given me ». As soon, therefore, as We had looked, from the height of the Apostolic dignity, upon the direction in which human affairs were going, and had seen the lamentable state of civil society, We were filled with bitter sorrow. For how could it be that We, the common Father of all, should [not be pierced to the heart by the spectacle of Europe and the world, - a spectacle perhaps the darkest and saddest in all human history? It

1 Jn., XXI, 15-17. 2 Id., X, 16. 3 Id., XVII, 11.

seems as if the days foretold by Christ had indeed come: « You shall « hear of wars and rumours of wars. - For nation shall rise against 1 nation, and kingdom against kingdom ». The dread image of war over- shadows the world, and absorbs nearly every thought. The strongest and wealthiest nations are in conflict. What wonder, then, that furn- ished as they are with the latest weapons devised by military science, their struggle is causing enormous slaughter. There is no end to the ruin, no end to the deaths; each day sees the earth flowing with fresh blood, and covered with dead and wounded. Who would think that the nations, thus armed against each other, are all descended from one ancestor, share the same nature, belong to the same human family? Who could realize that they are brethren, children of the same Father in heaven? And while the mighty hosts are contending in the fury of combat, cities, families, individuals, are being oppressed by those evils and miseries which follow at the heels of war; day by day the num- bers increase of widows and orphans; the paths of commerce are blocked; the fields are left unfilled; the arts are at a standstill; the rich are made poor, the poor still more destitute, all are made to mourn. Shocked by so great evils, We have held it to be Our duty, at the very beginning of Our supreme Pontificate, and as the first act of Our Apostolic ministry, to take up and repeat the last words that fell from the lips of Our Predecessor - a pontiff of illustrious and so holy me- mory; and therefore We earnestly beseech Princes and Rulers that, moved by the sight of so many tears, so much blood, already shed, they delay not to bring back to their peoples the life-giving blessings of peace. When the divine Redeemer first appeared upon earth, the glad tidings was sung by Angels' voice, so now, may God in his mercy grant that, at the beginning of Our labour as Christ's Vicar, the same 2 voice be heard proclaiming: « Peace on earth to men of good will ». We beg of those who hold in their hands the destinies of peoples, to give heed to that voice. If their rights have been violated, they can certainly find other ways and other means of obtaining a remedy; to these, laying aside the weapons of war, let them have recourse in sin- cerity of conscience, and good will. With no view to Our own self- interest do We speak thus, but in charity towards them and towards all nations. Let them not suffer Our voice of father and friend to pass away unheeded.

1 Mt., XXIV, 6-7. 2 Lk., II., 14.

But it is not only the murderous struggle now going on that is ruining the nations, and filling Us with anxious alarm. There is an- other dreadful evil, which goes deep down in modern society, an evil that inspires fear in the minds of thoughtful men, because

while it has already caused, and is threatening still to cause immense mischief to nations, it must also be recognised as the true source of the present deplorable conflict. Truly, as soon as the rules and dictates of Christ- ian wisdom, which are the assured basis of stability and peace, came to be disregarded in the ordering of public life, the very structure of the State began to be shaken to its fall; and there has also ensued so great a change of thought and conduct, that, unless God comes to the rescue, the dissolution of human society itself would seem to be at hand. The more prominent disorders are these: the lack of mutual love among men; disregard for authority; unjust quarrels between the various classes; material prosperity become the absorbing object of human endeavour, as though there were nothing higher and better to be gained. These We regard as the four chief causes why the world is so terribly shaken. We must labour earnestly therefore, by putting in practice Christian principles, to remove such disorders from our midst, if indeed we have at heart the common peace and welfare. When Jesus Christ came from heaven for the very purpose of restor- ing the kingdom of peace, which had been ruined by the envy of Satan, he chose no other foundation for it than that of brotherly love. Hence those words of his so often repeated: « A new commandment I 1 « give unto you, that you love one another »; « This is my command- 2 « ment that you love one another » ; « These things I command 3 « you, that you love one another » ; as though the whole scope and purpose of his coming were to make men love each other. To stimu- late us to this love, what motives has he not set before us? He bids us to lift up our eyes to heaven: « For one is your Father, who is in 4 « heaven ». Setting aside every difference of race, of language and of interest, he puts the selfsame prayer on the lips of all: « Our Father 5 « who art in heaven »; he even teaches that the heavenly Father in bestowing nature's gifts, is not swayed by our deserving: « Who maketh « his sun to rise upon the good and bad, and raineth upon the just

1 Jn., XIII, 34. 2 Id., XV, 18. 3 Id., ibid., 17. 4 Mt., XXIII, 9. 5 Id., VI, 9.

1 « and the unjust ». He further declares that we are all brethren: « But ail 2 « you are brethren »; and brethren of Himself: « That he might be the 3 « first-born amongst many brethren » . Then, what ought most power- fully to urge us to brotherly love, even towards those whom our natural pride would lead us to despise, he went so far as to identify himself with the meanest of men, in whom he wished us to recognise his own personal dignity: « As long as you did it to one of these my least 4 « brethren, you did it to me » . What more ? At the close of his life, he earnestly besought of the Father, that all who should believe in him might be made one by the bond of charity: « As Thou Father in 5 « me and I in Thee » . Lastly, when hanging on the Gross, he poured out his blood upon us all, so that, as if compacted and joined together in one body, mutual love should be found amongst us, just as mutual sympathy is found amongst the members of the same body. But in these times the conduct of men is far different. Never perhaps was human brotherhood more preached than now; nay, it is pretended that, without any help from the teaching of the Gospel, or from the work of Christ and the Church, the spirit of brotherhood has been one of the highest creations of modern civilisation. Yet the truth is, that men never acted towards each other in less brotherly fashion than now. Race hatreds are becoming almost a frenzy; nation is divi- ded from nation more by enmity and jealousy than by geographical position; in the same city, within the same walls, the different ranks are on fire with mutual envy; all take as their supreme law their own self-interest. You see, venerable Brethren, how necessary it is that no effort should be spared to bring back among men the power of the charity of Christ. This shall be Our constant endeavour, the chosen task of Our Pontificate; to this We exhort you to attend. Let us not grow weary of teach- ing and practising the injunction of the Apostle St. John: « That we 6 love one another ». Doubtless there are numerous benevolent institutions now doing useful and valuable work, but they not prove to be of real benefit, unless they help in promoting a true love of God and

* Mt., V, 45. 2 Id., XXIII, 8. 8 Bom., VIII, 29. * Mt., XXV, 40. 5 Jn., XVII, 21. 6 I Jn., Ill, 23.

our neighbour; without this they are nothing worth, for: « He that loveth 1 not, abideth in death • >.

We have said that another cause of social disorder lies in this, that authority is generally disregarded. For as soon as human authority began to emancipate itself from God, the creator and master of the universe, and to seek its origin in man's free choice, the bonds between superiors and subjects were relaxed so that now they would almost seem not to exist. An unbridled spirit of independence, joined with pride, has gradually permeated everywhere, not sparing even the family, where nature itself discloses authority in the clearest light; what is more to be deplored, the evil has even reached the sanctuary. Hence the contempt for law; hence the insubordination of the masses; hence the petulant criticism of the commands of authority; hence the continual attempts to break

its power; hence the monstrous, deeds of those, who, making profession of anarchy, have no respect either for the property or the lives of others. In presence of this perversity of thought and deed - a perversity destructive of all human society - We, to whom has been committed the guardianship of divine truth, cannot be silent; and We admonish all of that doctrine which cannot be changed by man's will: « There is « no power but from God; and those that are, are ordained of God »..* • All power, therefore, whether of the sovereign or of subordinate author- ities, comes from God. Wherefore St. Paul teaches the duty of obey- ing, not in any way, but for conscience sake, those who have the rule over us, except when what is commanded is against the law of God: « Wherefore be subject of necessity, not only for wrath, but also for 3 « conscience sake ». In agreement with this are the words of the Prince of the Apostles: « Be ye subject therefore to every human creature for « God's sake: whether it be to the king as excelling, or to governors as 4 « sent by him ». From this doctrine the same Apostle of the Gentiles draws the conclusion, that whoever is a rebel against lawful human authority, is a rebel against God, and prepares for himself eternal punish- ment: « Therefore he that resisteth the power, resisteth the ordinance 5 « of God. And they that resist, purchase to themselves damnation » .

1 I Jn., Ill, 14. 2 Bom., XIII, 1. 3 Ibid., 5. 4 I Pet., II, 13-14. 5 Bom., XIII, %,

Let Princes and Rulers of the peoples bear this in mind and bethink themselves whether it be wise and salutary that public authority should divorce itself from the holy religion of Jesus Christ, in which it may find so powerful a support. Let them seriously consider whether it be politically wise to banish from public instruction the teaching of the Gospel and of the Church. Experience teaches only too well that where religion is away public authority falls. It generally happens to States as it happened to our first parent after his failure in his duty to God. As in him, scarcely had the will been rebel to God when the passions broke loose and rebelled against the will; so too, whenever those who have the rule over peoples disdain the authority of God, the peoples in their turn are prompt to hold lightly the authority of man. Certainly there remains the usual expedient of suppressing rebellion by violence; but where is the gain? Violence may subdue the body, it cannot con- quer the will.

The double element of cohesion in the body social, that is, the union of the members among themselves by mutual charity, and the union of the members with the head by obedience to authority, being thus destroyed or weakened, what wonder, venerable Brethren, that modern society should show itself as divided into two opposing forces struggling against each other fiercely, and without truce? Over against those who have happened to receive, or have industriously earned a certain amount of wealth, there are ranged a number of the indigent and of workers, inflamed with ill will, because, possessing the same human nature as those better off, they do not enjoy equal fortune. When once they have been deluded by the sophistries of demagogues, to whom they generally show themselves most submissive, who shall per- suade them that, because men have equality of nature, it does not follow that they must have equality of rank in social life, but that each holds that position which, not frustrated by circumstances, he has gained for himself? When, therefore, the poor assail the rich, as though these had appropriated to themselves what belongs to others, they are acting not only against justice and charity, but even against reason, particularly because they themselves might better their own position by force of honourable labour. It would be superfluous to point out the consequences, disastrous alike to individuals and to the community, that flow from this class hatred. We all know and deplore those frequent strikes by which the whole of public life, even in its most necessary activities, is suddenly

checked; and then the riotous outbreaks, in which recourse is frequently- had to arms, and this followed by bloodshed. We will not now repeat the arguments that show the untenable- ness of Socialism and similar errors. This has been done with supreme wisdom by Our predecessor Leo XIII, in his memorable Encyclicals; but We appeal to you, venerable Brethren, to use your endeavours that that authoritative teaching be not forgotten; that by means of Catholic associations and congresses, of sermons and the Catholic press, it be adequately explained and enforced, as circumstances may require. But, above all, and We do not hesitate to repeat it, let us make it our care, using every argument supplied by the Gospel, by reason and by public or private good, to stimulate all men to mutual brotherly love in accordance with the divine law of charity. This brotherly love does not set itself to sweep away all differences of rank and condition - this is no more possible than it is possible in a living body that all the members should have the same place and function - but it has power to make those of a higher rank act towards those of a lower, not only with justice, as is indeed imperative, but also with good-will, and kind- ness, and consideration; and it makes those of a lower rank to be glad at the prosperity of others, and to have confidence in their readiness

to help; just as in the same family the younger-trust to the care and protection of the elder.

The evils We have just been deploring find their cause, venerable Brethren, in a deeper root, and unless the good use their efforts to destroy it, We shall look in vain for the realization of Our desire for a solid and lasting peace among men. What that root is, the Apostle 1 tells us: « The desire of money is the root of all evils ». And to this root are indeed attributable all the evils now afflicting the world. When godless schools, moulding as wax the tender hearts of the young, when an unscrupulous press, continually playing upon the inexper- ienced minds of the multitude, when those other agencies that form public opinion, have succeeded in propagating the deadly error that man ought not to look for a happy eternity; that it is only here that happiness is to be found, in the riches, the honours, the pleasures o this life, it is not surprising that men, with their inextinguishable desire of happiness, should attack what stands in the way of that happiness with all the impelling force of their desire. But since earthly goods are

1 I Tim., V I , 10.

unequally divided, and since it is the office of the State to prevent individuals seizing at their own will what belongs to others, it has come about that hatred has been engendered against the public authority, that envy of the more fortunate has taken hold of the less fortunate, and that the different classes of fellow-citizens are in open antagonism, - those who have not striving by every means to obtain, and the others striving to keep what they have, and to increase it. Foreseeing these things, Christ our Lord, in the divine sermon on the Mount, thought it good to explain what are man's true beatitudes even here on earth, and so to lay the foundations, as it were, of Christian philosophy. Men far removed from the faith, have yet seen in this teaching a supreme wisdom, and the most perfect form of reli- gious and moral doctrine; and indeed, all agree that before Christ, who is truth itself, no one ever spoke of these things as he has spoken, with such dignity, such power, and so exalted a sentiment of love. Now the deep and underlying thought of this divine philosophy is, that the good things of this life have only the appearance without the reality of good, and so cannot bestow true happiness. In the truth of God's word, riches and pleasure are so far from bringing true happiness, that to secure true happiness we must rather, renounce these things for the love of God. « Blessed are ye poor... Blessed are ye « that weep now... Blessed shall you be when men shall hate you, and « shall separate you, and shall reproach you, and cast out your name as 1 « evil ». That is to say, if we bear patiently, as we ought, the sorrows, hardships, and miseries of this life, we open for ourselves a way to the possession of those true and imperishable goods, «which God hath 2 « prepared for those who love him » . But this important teaching of the faith is neglected by too many, and by not a few is altogether for- gotten. It is for you, venerable Brethren, to make this teaching live again amongst men; without it men and communities of men will never find peace. We urge therefore all who are suffering under any kind of hardship, not to keep their eyes fixed on earth, which is but a place of exile, but to lift them up to heaven, whither we are tending; for 3 « we have not here a lasting city, but we seek one that is to come ». In times of adversity, with which God tries the steadiness of their service, let them often reflect on the greatness of the reward when

1 Lk., VI, 20-22. 2 I Cor., II, 9. 3 Hebr., XIII, 13.

they have come victorious out of the struggle: «For that which is at « present momentary and light of our tribulation, worketh for us above 1 « measure exceedingly an eternal weight of glory ». Lastly, it should be one of your chief cares, venerable Brethren, with all zeal and energy to make faith in the supernatural live again amongst men, and with faith the pursuit, the desire and the hope of what is eternal; for this work We ask the cooperation not only of the clergy, but. of all those Catholics who, banded together in various societies, are labouring for God's honour and man's true good. The more this faith grows amongst men the more will the feverish pursuit of earthly vanities cease, and as charity grows strong, social conflicts and tumults will gradually die away.

And now leaving this subject, and turning to what more imme- diately concerns the state of the Church, Our spirit, saddened by the present calamities of the world, finds some relief. For, in addition to the manifest proofs of the divine power and stability of the Church, We find no little consolation in the admirable fruits of the laborious Pontificate of Our predecessor Pius X, who during that Pontificate adorned the Apostolic See with the example of a life in every way saintly. It is owing to him that We see the religious spirit of the clergy everywhere intensified; the piety of the faithful aroused; a disciplined activity promoted in Catholic associations; the sacred hierarchy con- solidated or extended; the education of aspirants to the priesthood promoted according to the strict demands of ecclesiastical legislation and the needs of our own times; the danger of rash innovations removed from the teaching of the sacred sciences; music made to bear a worthy part in the solemn service of God, and

the dignity of the liturgy in- creased; the knowledge of Christianity more widely spread by fresh contingents of ministers of the Gospel. Such are the services rendered to the Church by Our Predecessor, and those who come after us will gratefully remember them. But since, God permitting, the field spoken of in the parable is always exposed to the evil working of the « enemy», there never will come a time when we shall not have to be on our guard lest the cockle do harm to the good wheat. For this reason, applying to Ourselves what God spoke to the prophet; « Lo, I have set thee this day over the nations and 2 « over kingdoms, to root up... and to destroy, and to build, and to plant », We shall labour incessantly to the best of Our power in opposing what

1 II Cor., IV, 17. 2 Jerm., I, 10.

is evil, in promoting what is good, until it shall please the Prince of Pastors to demand an account of Our stewardship. In this Our first Encyclical We find opportunity to set before you, venerable Brethren, some of the chief matters calling for Our solicitude, so that by your now getting ready to help We may the sooner obtain the good We desire. The first element on which the success of any society of men depends is the concord of its members. We shall therefore make it one of Our chief cares to do away with, and to prevent, dissension and discord amongst Catholics, and thus to secure unity of plan and of action. The enemies of God and the Church clearly see that a way to victory over us is opened, whenever our defence is weakened by divided counsels; hence they are ever on the alert, when they find us united, to divide us by craftily sowing in our midst the seed of discord. Would that their scheme had not been so often successful, to the great detriment of religion. For this reason it is wrong that anyone should set aside the commands of lawful authority on the pretence that he does not approve of them; let each submit his opinion to the judgment of authority, and then obey as a duty of conscience. No private person is allowed, by the medium of books or of newspapers or of public speeches, to put himself forward as teacher in the Church. All know to whom God has given the teaching authority of the Church; to him it belongs to decide when and how he shall speak; the duty of others is to receive his words with reverence and obedience. In matters about which the Holy See has not given a decision, and in which, without injury to faith and ecclesiastical discipline, there may be differences of opinion, each may lawfully defend his own. But in such disputes there must be no offensive language, for this may lead to grave breaches of charity; each is free to maintain his own opinion, but with propriety, and if others do not accept his view, he must not cast suspicion on. their faith or spirit of discipline. We desire that that practice, lately come into use, of using distinctive names by which Catholics are marked off from Catholics, should cease; such names must be avoided, not only as « profane novelties of words », that are neither true nor just, but also because they lead to grave disturbance and confusion in the Catholic body. It is of the nature of the Catholic faith that nothing can be added to it, nothing taken away; it is either accepted in full or rejected in full: « This is the Catholic faith, which unless a man 1 « believe faithfully and steadfastly, he cannot be saved » . There is no

1 Symb. Athanas.

need to qualify by fresh epithets the profession of this faith; let it be enough for a man to say: « Christian is my name, Catholic my sur- « name »; only let him take heed to be in truth what he calls himself. As for those who devote themselves to the good of the Catholic cause, the Church now asks of them not to be ov.er eager about useless questions, but, following the leadership of him whom Christ has appointed guardian and interpreter of the truth, to use all their power to preserve the faith in fullness and freedom from error. There are still men, and these not a few, who, as the Apostle says: « having « itching ears, when they will not endure sound doctrine, according to « their desires will heap to themselves teachers, and will indeed turn 1 « away their hearing from the truth, but will be turned unto fables ». Some there are who, puffed up and emboldened in mind by the won- derful advance of natural science, - an advance due to the gift of God, - have gone so far in their rashness that, exalting their own judgment above the authority of the Church, they have not hesitated to reduce the deep things of God, and the whole revelation of God, to the measure of their own understanding, and to accomodate them to the modern spirit. Hence have arisen the monstrous errors of Moder- nism, which Our Predecessor justly declared to be « a synthesis of all heresies », and which he solemnly condemned. That condemnation, venerable Brethren, We now renew to the full; and since this so pesti- lential evil has not been altogether stamped out, but even yet secretly creeps here and there, We admonish all to be most carefully on their guard against its contagion; one can well say of it, what Job said of another plague: « It is a fire that devoureth even to destruction, and 2 « rooteth up all things that spring ». We desire that Catholics should reject, not only the errors of Modernism, but also its tendency, - what is called the Modernistic spirit; a

spirit that fastidiously rejects what is ancient, and is ever on the search for novelties, - novelties in the way of speaking of divine things, in the celebration of divine worship, in Catholic practices, and even in the exercises of private devotion. We desire, therefore, that the old rule be religiously observed: « Let « nothing be introduced but what has been handed down»; a rule which, while being inviolably observed in matters of faith, must be taken as a guide also in matters liable to change; although even here the sentence holds good: « Not new things, but in a new way ».

1 II Tim., IV, 3-4. 2 Job, XXXI, 12.

Knowing, venerable Brethren, that men are greatly helped in their open profession and proper practice of the faith by mutual encoura- gement and example, We rejoice exceedingly'at the multiplication of Catholic associations. But not only do We wish them to increase, We also desire that they nourish under Our protection and favour; and they will flourish, if they continue faithfully to observe the regulations that have been given, or may be given, by the Holy See. Let all members of such associations, who are labouring for God and the Church, keep ever in mind that saying of the divine wisdom: « An 1 « obedient man shall speak of victory »; for unless they are obedient to God by following the guidance of the Church, they must not expect the help of God, and will labour in vain. But in addition to these things, you know, venerable Brethren, that there is need of the prudent and assiduous work of those whom Christ our Lord has sent as labourers into his harvest, that is to say, of the clergy. For this reason you are aware that it is in the highest degree incumbent upon you to promote in your clergy that holiness of life which is demanded by their state, and by perfect discipline and training properly to prepare for their holy calling aspirants of the sanctuary. Although your care needs no exhortation in this matter, nevertheless We exhort, and even beseech you, to attend to it with all possible zeal. For it is a matter that which none can be of more importance for the good of the Church; but since Our predecessors of happy memory, Pope Leo XIII, and Pius X, have attended to this subject, We add nothing further. Only this We beg, that the instructions of those most wise Pontiffs, and especially those given by Pius X, of saintly memory, in his Exhortatio ad clerum, may by your effective oversight be always kept in mind, and most scrupulously observed. There is one thing about which We cannot be silent. We wish to admonish all the clergy, whom We love as most dear sons, how absolutely necessary it is for their own salvation, and for the fruitfulness of their ministry, that they be perfectly united with, and obedient to, their own bishops. We have already deplored that some ministers of the sanctuary have been infected by that spirit of independence and insubordination so characteristic of these days; and it has not unfrequently happened for the Pastors of the Church to meet with sorrow and opposition where they had every right to expect consolation and help. May those who have been so unhappily forgetful of their duty,

Prov.. XXI, 28.

seriously reflect that the authority possessed by bishops, whom « the 1 « Holy Ghost hath placed to rule the Church of G o d » , is a divine authority; and if, as We have seen, those who resist any lawful author- ity resist God, far more wickedly do they act who refuse obedience to the bishops, whom God has consecrated by the seal of his own power. « Since charity », says St. Ignatius Martyr, « does not suffer me to be « silent in your regard, therefore have I been forward to admonish you, « that you be in agreement with the mind of God. For Jesus Christ; « our inseparable life, is the mind of the Father, as the bishops also, set « throughout the earth, are in the mind of Jesus Christ. Wherefore it is 2 « fitting that you run in agreement with the mind of the bishop ». The language of the illustrious martyr has been repeated, generation after generation, by the Fathers and Doctors of the Church. Owing to the difficulties of our time, the burden of the bishops is already too heavy; heavier still is their anxiety for the protection of their flocks: « For they watch as being to render an account of your 3 « souls ». Is it not cruel that anyone, by refusing proper obedience, should increase the weight and anxietes of their office ? To such a one 4 the Apostle would say: « This is not expedient for you »; and this because: « The Church is a people united with the priest, and a flock 5 « cleaving to the shepherd »; therefore he that is not with the bishop, is not with the Church.

And now, venerable Brethren, at the close of this letter, Our mind goes back spontaneously to the thought of peace with which We began; We pray with unceasing prayer for the good of men and of the Church that this disastrous war may cease; for the good of men, so that by the bringing back of peace they may go forward on the path of true progress; for the good of Christ's Church, that it may be left unhindered to bear help and salvation to every part of the world. Too long has the Church been curtailed of its necessary freedom of action, ever since the Head of the Church, the supreme Pontiff, began to lack that defence of his freedom which the providence of God had raised up during the course of centuries. The

loss of that protection has inevitably caused no light anxiety in the Catholic body; for all the children of the Roman

1 Act., XX, 28. 2 In Epist, ad Ephes , III. 3 Hebr., XIII, 17. 4 Ibid. 5 S. Cypr. Ep. 66 (al. 69).

Pontiff, whether near or living afar, have a right not to be left in doubt concerning the possession by their common Father of a true and unden- iable freedom in the exercise of his Apostolic ministry. While We pray for the speedy return of peace to the world, We also pray that an end be put to the abnormal state in which the Head of the Church is placed - a state which in many ways is an impediment to the common tranquillity. Our Predecessor have protested, not from self-interest, but from a sense of sacred duty, against this state of things; those protests We renew, and for the same reason - to protect the rights and dignity of the Apostolic See. It remains for Us, venerable Brethren, to lift up our voices in prayer to God, in whose hands are the hearts of princes, and of all responsible for the continuance of the scourges now afflicting us, and to cry in the name of all mankind: « Give peace, O Lord, in our days*. 1 And may he, who said of himself: « I am the Lord ... I make peace > f

be moved by our prayers, and speedily still the tempest now tossing civil and religious society. And may the Blessed Virgin be mercifully at hand to assist us - she who bore the Prince of Peace; may she regard and protect with a mother's love Us in Our lowliness, Our Pon- tificate, the Church, and with the Church the souls of all men redeemed by the divine Blood of her Son. As a pledge of heaven's gifts, and in sign of our good will We lovingly bestow on you, venerable Brethren, on your clergy, and on your people, the Apostolic Blessing. Given in Rome, at St. Peter's, on the Feast of All Saints, Novem- ber 1st. 1914, in the first year of Our Pontificate.

* Isai, XLV, 6-7.

BENEDICTUS PP. XV

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